The Future of Work and Organizations
Diversity and Inclusion



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Today: experience first, then diagnose

Global Collaboration simulation — 80 minutes

Diversity lecture and applications — 75 minutes

By the end, you should be able to:

- define diversity and distinguish surface from deep-level diversity
- explain key challenges of managing diversity
- identify five forms of workplace discrimination
- select strategies that support an inclusive environment

The central question: how can organizations benefit from difference without allowing difference to become disadvantage?

Global Collaboration

- In global companies, people from anywhere in the world are expected to work effectively together.
- They need a common language to collaborate- often English, the *lingua franca* of many organizations.

You are going to be a part of a globally diverse four or five person senior management team of a hypothetical startup company.

The senior team has to work together to put together a presentation for a pitch to a venture capital firm in 15 minutes.

You will be **randomly** assigned to a role of: CEO, finance, marketing, or operations executives.

Global Collaboration Simulation (Tip of the Iceberg)

- Log in on the Harvard site
- You should see “Welcome to the Global Collaboration Simulation”
- You will have about 10 minutes to read about your role

  Note you will be randomly assigned to roles and teams.

ShineTek Scenario Roles
CEO, OPS, FIN, and MKTG

CEO is an entrepreneur with a PhD in engineering and material science and is based in Boston, MA. CEO is a native English speaker.

OPS is based in Shenzhen and is a native English speaker.

FIN is based in Boston, MA but is currently visiting VC firms in California. FIN is a nonnative English speaker.

MKTG is based in Singapore and is a nonnative English speaker.

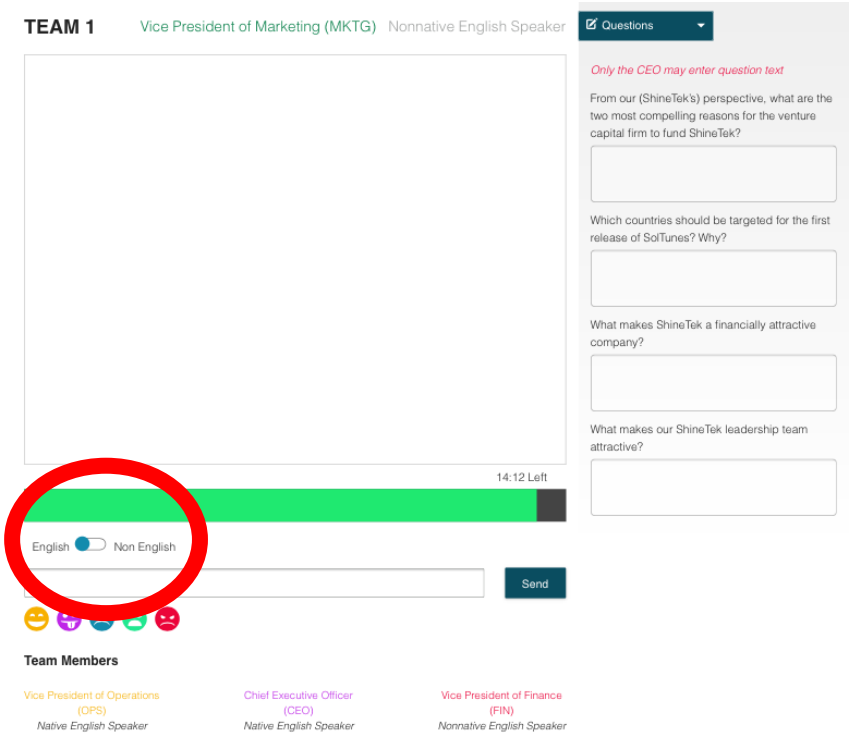
shared 1st language

Important Simulation Information

Text-based chat is used to simulate global collaboration

- There are **no technical defects** in the chat room
- **All team members speak English** (native & nonnative)
- **FIN & MKTG/COM can speak a non-English** language, but CEO and OPS won't understand

  Look for English vs. non-English buttons to choose language



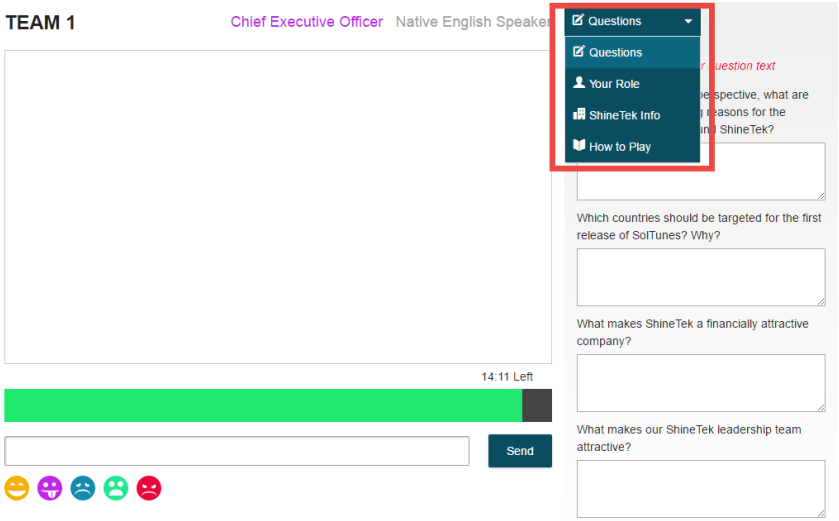
Ground Rules

- ✓ **15 minutes** to complete presentation
- ✓ First, **read** your role requirements
- ✓ Refer to your role info in **“Your Role” tab**
- ✓ **Please refrain** from talking to others
- ✓ Presentations will be submitted & may be viewed randomly
- ✓ Note your **team number** on the right side of the screen
- ✓ I will start the conference

Note: Not everyone sees the same thing

Reminder

- Once your session has begun you can reference both “How to Play” and role /company specific information in the dropdown menu on the upper right-hand side of the screen.

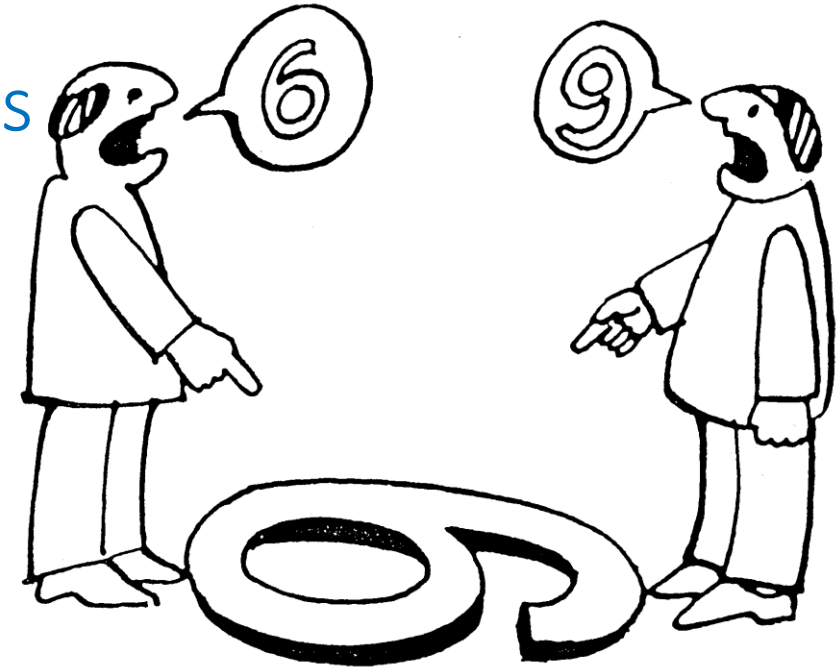


Debrief

What **insights** did you gain into
working as a native vs. nonnative speaker?

What **insights** did you gain into
the challenges of global collaboration?

Communication Obstacles



- Avoidance behaviours
- Social categorization
- Mutual knowledge problems
- Trust

Perspective taking fosters trust and mutual understanding

(Cramton, 2001; Cramton et al., 2004; Hinds et al., 2014; Neeley, 2013)

Rules of Engagement for Global Team Meetings

Fluent Speakers	Less Fluent Speakers	Team Leaders
✓Slow down the pace and use familiar language (e.g., fewer idioms) ✓Refrain from dominating the conversation ✓Ask: "Do you understand what I am saying?" ✓Listen actively **"dial down dominance"**	✓Resist avoidance behaviors ✓Refrain from reverting to your native language ✓Ask: "Do you understand what I am saying?" ✓If you don't understand others, ask them to repeat or explain **"dial up engagement"**	✓Strive to balance their speaking and listening ✓Actively draw contributions from all team members ✓Solicit participation from less fluent speakers in particular ✓Be prepared to define and interpret content **"balance for inclusion"**

Final Thoughts

- Cultivating a global mindset means integrating diverse knowledge, not just acquiring it.
- Language structures interaction- intentionally include, and anticipate frustration.



Icebreaker: does having a more diverse team automatically improve effectiveness and performance?

Diversity is broader than demographics

Diversity: any characteristic that makes people different from one another.

It includes identities, experience,language, expertise, values, personality and work preferences.

Representation asks who is present.

Inclusion asks whose contribution shapes the work.



Types of Team Diversity

- **Surface- level diversity**, which refers to attributes that are readily observable (e.g. team members' gender and age)
- **Deep-level diversity**: attributes that cannot be judged without (prolonged) interaction with the respective team member (e.g. personality and personal values)

(Bowers, Pharmer, and Salas, 2000; Harrison, Price, and Bell, 1998; Phillips and Loyd, 2006).

- **job-related diversity** vs. **job-unrelated diversity**

(van Dijk, van Engen, and van Knippenberg, 2012; van Knippenberg and Schippers, 2007)

- How much of what you identified was **surface-level** diversity vs. **deep diversity**?

Team Diversity and Team Performance

- Information processing/learning and effectiveness perspective- benefits more relevant when diversity is surface level.
- Spurs creativity and innovativeness
- Can improve decision making (e.g. helps disrupt unquestioned group decisions "groupthink").

(Açıkgöz, Günsel, Kuzey, and Seçgin, 2016; Bell, Villado, Lukasik, Belau, and Briggs, 2011; Stahl, Maznevski, Voigt, and Jonsen, 2010)



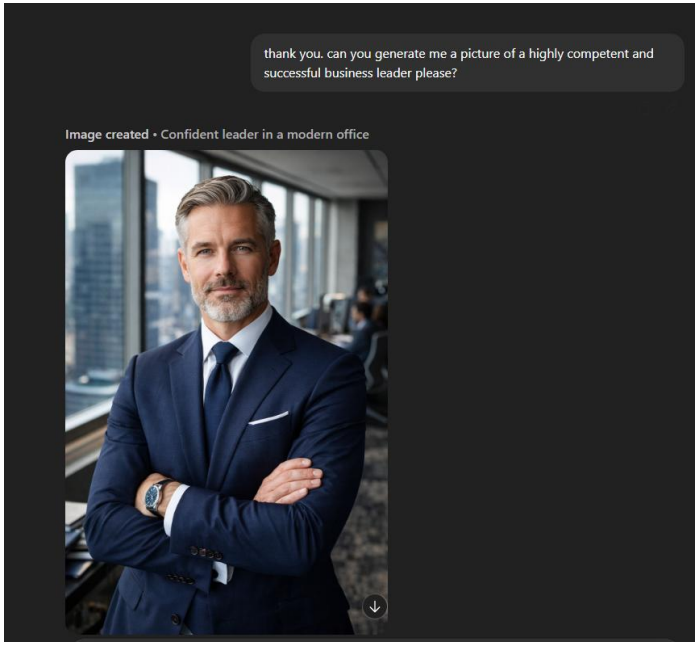
Diversity is better but homogeneity is easier

- Social categorization perspective-triggers conflict: hampers the interaction and cooperation within teams (Guillaume et al., 2017; van Knippenberg et al., 2004).

- Barriers for collaboration and coordination (Cabrales, Medina, Lavado, and Cabrera, 2008; Cheung, Gong, Wang, Zhou, and Shi, 2016).



Why do we have biases?



- They can help us make decisions quickly and efficiently, with little thought needed.
- They influence how we see the world and interact with others through **social perception and categorization**.

- Stereotypes: Impressions of groups that people form by associating the groups with particular characteristics

(Wittenbrink, Judd, & Park, 2001)

Managing diversity means managing everyday systems

Stereotypes can distort who is seen as competent, committed or leadership material.

Status and informal networks affect whose ideas travel and who receives opportunities.

Difference can increase misunderstanding, subgroup formation and conflict.

Policies may appear neutral while producing unequal access or outcomes.

Inclusion therefore depends on decisions, routines and relationships—not goodwill alone.

Hybrid work can make exclusion harder to see

The remote colleague contributes, but the room continues without acknowledging the point.

No rule is openly broken. Yet influence, information and belonging are unevenly distributed.

Quick diagnosis: exclusion, incivility—or both?

What one meeting practice would change the outcome?



Discrimination ranges from overt to easily normalized

Sexual harassment — unwanted sexual conduct creating a hostile or offensive environment.

Mockery and insults — jokes, slurs or negative stereotypes.

Intimidation — threats, bullying or coercion directed at members of a group.

Exclusion — being left out of opportunities, information, networks or decisions.

Incivility — disrespect, interruption, dismissal or ignoring someone's contribution.

What is happening in this team chat?

A colleague repeatedly mispronounces Samira’s name after correction. A meme about her accent receives laughing reactions. She is removed from a client call because it may be “easier for the customer.” When she objects, the manager replies: “Let’s keep this professional.”

Identify every form of discrimination that may be present.

Which act is easiest for the organization to dismiss?

What should the manager do immediately—and what system needs attention?

Quick Exercise

Recently, AI has been introduced into HR recruitment functions across all divisions of your multinational for reasons of efficiency, and objective fairness.

- You are a regional director in a market where local managers place considerable value on candidates' ability to build relationships and work effectively within highly interdependent teams. They argue that the new system misses important contextual information. It heavily weights individual certificates and keywords, while giving little recognition to locally relevant experience, collaborative capability or relationship-building. At the same time, they recognize that "local fit" can become a vague justification for bias.
- What legitimate information might the system be missing?
- When might "local fit" conceal stereotyping or discrimination?
- How could the organization combine consistency with contextual judgment?
- Who should be involved in auditing and redesigning the system?

AI does not remove responsibility for fairness

An AI tool ranks applicants. The team cannot explain why qualified candidates disappeared.

Technology may reproduce patterns embedded in data, criteria and past decisions.

Ask: What is optimized? Who might be disadvantaged? Who can challenge or appeal?

What comes first: pause, audit or human review?



Inclusion requires a system, not a single intervention

Relationships: common identity and meaningful contact.

Entry: inclusive recruitment, selection and role allocation.

Capability: training, feedback, mentoring and development.

Environment: culture, climate, leadership signals and accountability.

A strong approach aligns all four; one isolated initiative is easy to undermine.

Two relational strategies reduce “us versus them”



Common identity — a meaningful shared “we” around interdependent goals.

Contact — repeated cooperation, relatively equal status and norms supporting respect.

Did the simulation provide these conditions?

Recruitment and staffing change who enters—and where they land

Broaden outreach beyond familiar networks and signals of “fit.”

Use job-relevant, structured criteria and consistent assessment.

Audit who advances, who is rejected and where differences appear.

Avoid tokenism: representation without voice, support or advancement is fragile.

Which step is most vulnerable to informal judgment?

Training works best when it changes behaviour and opportunity

Build skill: perspective taking, interrupting bias, inclusive meetings, feedback and conflict handling.

Connect training to real decisions, practice, coaching and accountability.

Development matters too: stretch work, sponsorship, mentoring and transparent promotion routes.

A one-off awareness session cannot repair an exclusionary system.

Culture is what is valued; climate is what people experience

Diversity culture: shared assumptions about whether difference is genuinely valued and integrated.

Diversity climate: employees' shared perceptions of policies, practices and everyday treatment.

Official values and lived experience may diverge.

Ask: What evidence would you collect before calling an organization inclusive?

A three-minute inclusion audit

Choose a workplace, team or student organization.

1. Where could exclusion enter: recruitment, meetings, task allocation, evaluation or development?
2. Which form might be normalized or difficult to name?
3. Select one relational strategy and one organizational strategy.
4. What evidence would show the intervention worked?



Difference becomes an asset only when systems make it usable

Diversity includes visible identities and less visible values, experience, expertise and preferences.

It can expand information and judgment—but can also activate stereotypes, subgroups and unequal influence.

Discrimination may be overt or embedded in ordinary interactions and opportunities.

Inclusive organizations combine relationships, fair staffing, development, culture and climate.

Final question: Who is present, who is heard, and who can progress?

References

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